

Microsoft Embraces the Cloud

With Windows 8, Microsoft plans to embrace the cloud, by letting users take their workspace from one PC to another

Initial Public Offer

On August 19, 2004, Google offered an IPO in which 19,605,052 shares were offered at a price of \$85 per share

that a typical computer user indulges in. Google Docs is a seminal achievement, and yet Microsoft Office continues to be the choice of majority of the users. In India more than 90 per cent of computers are run pirated versions of Microsoft Office, even though the original version of Google Docs is available for free online.

Despite Google's best efforts, things are not moving towards the cloud space in a really big way. The desktop model of computing is not going to go away in near future. The only way the Chrome OS can make headway is by offering users a better desktop computing experience than Windows 7 does. Even the most fervent supporters of Google are not claiming that the company is capable of pulling off such a feat in near future. The version of Chrome OS that we are expecting towards the end of this year might not be able to garner more than a single digit market share if its desktop potentialities are not comparable to Windows 7. What users really need is a powerful OS, which is capable of taking care of all kinds of entertainment and work related needs. In order to reach out to a really large audience, the Chrome OS will have to support systems like MS Office, gaming software, all kinds of music and video players and much else.

The oft-repeated complaint about Windows is that it evokes the feel of the pre-Internet era. With the launch of Windows 7, the company has done a lot to change this perception. But there is the factor of cost. Windows 7 is pricey, as compared to Chrome OS being made available for free. It is possible that the netbooks powered by Chrome OS might turn out to be cheaper as compared to those powered by Windows 7. But free OS is not such a big deal. After all, there are so many Linux - a free OS - powered netbooks in the market that are also quite cheap, but they have a very limited appeal. Users don't mind paying a reasonable amount of money for the OS, if it is as good as Windows 7. So if any company dreams that netbooks powered with its OS will fly off the shelf just because they are cheap, then they are probably living in a fool's paradise.

Clearly the expectations are high from the Chrome OS, and Google will have to be at its innovative best to meet them

all. As of now netbook users are appreciating Windows 7, and the Redmond based company is claiming that 96% of the world's netbooks run on Windows. The Chrome OS must make it a point to be really good; otherwise it might not be able to wean users away from their more than 20-year-old addiction to Windows.



Google's core Chrome team with founders Larry Page and Sergey Brin during Chrome's launch in 2008. Photo: Reuters

Will Chrome OS merge with Android?

There is one OS battle that Google seems to be on verge of winning. Its Android OS is currently powering some of the hottest mobile phones. With advent of new handsets like Samsung Galaxy S and HTC Desire, Android has attained a kind of cult status. As of now the Symbian Operating system from Nokia is the number one in the mobile OS space, RIM the maker of BlackBerry occupies the number two spot, and Apple is at number three. But the amazing thing about Google's Android is its massive growth. If it continues to grow at the same pace, then by 2013, the Android might become the world's most favoured mobile OS. Microsoft's Windows Mobile is also in the race, but it is the Android that is creating the highest amount of buzz. Close to 10,000 new apps are being created every month to cater to the myriad needs of Android based smartphones.

What if Google were to have the same kind of success in the PC and netbook OS space? Google's success with Android must be giving nightmares to Microsoft, especially because Android has already made a foray into netbooks. Even though Google continues to stick to its official position that Android is only for mobiles, the truth is that it is possible for us to get hold of a netbook powered by this OS. Predict-

ably, these devices are slightly cheaper than what we would normally pay for a Windows powered netbook. But as it has been said earlier in this article, mere lowering of prices is not going to do much for winning over customers. If a free OS were the key to notch up big sales, then Linux would have been the world's top OS for many years. That is not the case. Linux powered systems have single digit market share.

There is also speculation that in future the Android and the Chrome OS might converge into a single platform that powers all kinds of devices, from smartphones, to netbooks, tablets and PCs. Google's co-founder Sergey Brin, has commented on the possibility of Chrome OS and Android coming together in the future. So if that is what is going to eventually happen, then why did Google start two different projects? This is part of the company's strategy for creating an atmosphere of friendly internal competition, between the teams developing Android and the Chrome OS. In the end, Google will be able to pick and choose the best ideas that emerge from the two projects and weld them into a single unbeatable OS. No one should harbour a figment of doubt about Google's determination to beat Microsoft in the OS game; Android and the Chrome OS are two pathways that, the company hopes, will lead it to a perfect OS.

Waiting for victor

It is not as if the success of Android means it is game over for Microsoft. In fact, the launch of Android might have helped Microsoft to formulate a strategy to tackle the Chrome OS when it is launched. It has already become obvious that the Android powered handsets are not that cheap. Case in point is the new Samsung Galaxy S, which costs around ₹30,000. Google has not been able to reduce prices in the mobile handset space. A similar scenario could play out in the netbook domain. If Google's Chrome OS is not able to reduce the cost of hardware significantly, then users will have much less incentive to move away from the tried and tested Windows platform. In any case, it is not going to be that easy to wean people away from desktop centric systems in which Microsoft continues to be in a dominant position. **d**